VIRTUOSO GUIDE TO RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Relationships Matter to Virtuosos

Virtuosos are Introverts with a truly enigmatic nature that makes them attractive to a wide range of people. They have a creative spontaneity that keeps boredom at bay, they know how to go with the flow, and they rarely seem to get stressed out. This doesn't mean, however, that relationships come easily to them.

While they can be a lot of fun, Virtuosos are notoriously reserved when it comes to their deepest thoughts and feelings. They often feel a need to withdraw into their own world, both to recharge and to be free of the expectations of others. They push boundaries in every sense and live life primarily in the present tense.

Given Virtuosos' inherent contradictions and paradoxes, "I never know what to expect from you" is a common refrain among their friends and loved ones. People with the Virtuoso personality type may be laid-back one moment, then unexpectedly stubborn or vocal the next. They can be fiercely loyal in one type of relationship but cavalier in another. The combination of these factors can make them difficult to get to know.

Virtuosos may leap from one relationship to another, trying to escape any sense of constraint or boredom. They also shy away from emotionally charged conversations, leaving important things unsaid. When friends or partners do venture into the realm of emotions by expressing feelings and preferences, Virtuosos may struggle to provide support and empathy. Instead, they may say something insensitive or simply give a look of confusion that's too often mistaken for disdain.

Fortunately, Virtuosos are always looking for opportunities to help the people they care about, whether by fixing their car or cracking a much-needed joke. People with this personality type uplift their loved ones, strengthening their relationships through a combination of cheerful energy and practical creativity.

Throughout this e-book, we'll discuss how Virtuosos' traits manifest within and how they influence their romantic relationships, friendships, and the parent-child dynamic. By taking an in-depth look not only at their strengths but also at the potential issues that could spring up, Virtuosos can build thriving relationships that contribute to a rich and meaningful life.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Romantic Relationships

The often enigmatic traits of Virtuosos mean that dating people with this personality type can be a very complex yet fascinating experience. Their Thinking trait is likely to give them an air of cold detachment, but it's offset by their Observant trait and tactical preference for Prospecting in ways that can be very attractive to potential partners.

Virtuosos live in the present, looking for new activities and experiences while avoiding routine and strict schedules. People with this personality type also do their best to resist any attempts to control them, either directly or indirectly. All this needs to be remembered by anyone dating Virtuosos.

Dating and Single Virtuosos

Virtuosos are very independent and need a lot of personal space, especially in their personal lives. It's important to note that they gravitate toward tangible and practical activities and are likely to try to change their romantic partners' habits if their approaches to life are somewhat different. In certain scenarios (e.g., if their partners belong to one of the Sentinel personality types) this can be a great thing, enlivening their love affairs and keeping the fires burning for many, many years. In other cases, both types may exhaust each other if neither agrees to compromise – Virtuosos may feel smothered and restless, while their sweethearts may be frustrated by what they're likely to see as irresponsibility and unpredictability.

Virtuoso personalities see their romantic obligations as something to be developed daily; even if they say, "I do," they're more likely to mean,

"I do… until something changes." This doesn't mean Virtuosos are unwilling or unable to develop and maintain lifelong relationships, just that they simply dislike committing to anything without an exit clause in place. Virtuoso dating partners or long-term lovers should be aware of this tendency and try to avoid pushing their Virtuoso partners to commit too early in their relationships.

People with the Virtuoso personality type aren't very emotionally demonstrative and are likely to try hard to protect their feelings. Their emotions run deep, and their general discomfort with them means they stay hidden. Falling in love with these types can mean foregoing a lot of expressive emotions in the relationship.

Virtuosos live in the present, and so do their feelings – they may be very passionate one day and focused on something else the next. Their romantic partners shouldn't take this too personally, as it's simply how the Virtuoso mind works. These types are also likely to express their feelings in more tangible ways, such as improving the house or crafting an intricate gift.

Virtuosos in the Bedroom

Sexually, Virtuosos see intimacy as something that's both an art and a source of pleasure. They're unlikely to be too strict or traditional when it comes to sex – either when dating, or later in their relationships. Sensual and practical, they're able to use all five senses without any effort at all and are likely to encourage their partners to simply relax and have fun.

Potential Role Pairings

Each Role contains a set of four personality types that share core characteristics and, therefore, are similar to each other. Exploring the Roles and their potential romantic interactions with Virtuosos can provide a helpful framework for navigating relationships. However, some caution is warranted. Life is messy and full of hard decisions. People aren't like puzzle pieces that fit other pieces in some perfect, predictable way. Too many variables affect all relationships.

Traits may manifest in distinct or obvious ways, but sometimes they're a subtle undercurrent of someone's personality. Often traits can become subdued or exaggerated over time, as people adapt to societal and other pressures. When considering traits, too rigid an interpretation of another's tendencies can confine a romantic partner into an identity that doesn't fit. A more reasonable goal is to discover how traits might influence each unique person within a couple. In loving relationships, personal conversations outdo even the most reliable personality studies.

Although the information provided here can help readers navigate relationships better, we won't pretend to offer exact solutions, nor predict perfect romantic partners through personality typing alone. However, the data provided by personality typing can be a powerful tool for romantic exploration, especially in creating deeper understanding and meeting each other's needs – and like any tool, it's best used with education, patience, and practice.

Virtuoso-Analyst Relationships

Both Virtuosos and Analysts prefer rationality, and neither is very comfortable in the realm of emotions. This combination can create compatible couples who savor each other's logic, or it can hinder the deepening of their emotional lives, depending on the individuals and their overall needs and desires. Luckily, in different ways, both types are focused on finding solutions – and having this in common can enhance their relationships.

Balanced Virtuoso-Analyst Relationships

Analysts are Intuitive, Thinking types, and when they begin a relationship with Virtuosos (who are more practical Explorers), these relationships can be challenging, yet potentially rewarding. Analysts have heads full of ideas, visions for the future, and complicated systems. They seek and absorb as much knowledge at they can and engage in a constant restructuring of ideas and concepts.

Virtuosos live fully in the present. They're curious about everything – except long-winded conversations based on abstractions and ideas. They're always looking for what is new and exciting. They seek challenges of a material and physical nature – a musical instrument or a craft, for example. Yet both types enjoy solving things: Analysts work to resolve more conceptual problems, while Virtuosos seek solutions to real and immediate problems.

So, what happens when Virtuosos and Analysts meet for a date? Starting from an optimistic place, Analysts might impress Virtuosos with their theories for a while, but only if they can connect them to something practical. Technically oriented Analysts talking about writing computer code, for example, may impress Virtuosos who typically appreciate tools and devices. Analysts, in turn, may enjoy Virtuosos' practical perspectives and how they might tinker with the program in their own improvisational ways.

When Analysts and Virtuosos become serious and commit to one another, each type might appreciate the other's lack of concern for social convention. They can go through life together without worrying too much about what other people think about them or their love affair – Virtuosos because of their independence and unique approach to life, and Analysts because conventions are often outdated, logically speaking.

Virtuoso-Analyst partners also tend to appreciate the breathing room likely to be granted by their partners. Neither type is likely to feel an emotional need for the constant presence of the other. Analysts can seem entirely detached from their home lives when preoccupied with a project. This could work out well for Virtuosos, who need their own time to pursue interests. Nobody would ever accuse these couples of smothering each other.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Analyst Relationships

When the schism between the Intuitive and Observant traits becomes too great to bridge, Virtuoso-Analyst partners may spend a lot of time thinking about what they're doing wrong. They may wonder why their significant others seem to misunderstand them all the time, and why they don't connect. When these concerns arise, Virtuosos may want to administer a daring fix immediately, whereas Analyst may want to ponder, intellectually dissect, and then develop a mental blueprint toward a solution.

While Virtuosos aren't highly sensitive to the opinions of others, Analysts can come across as condescending, and may convey to Virtuosos that their work or contribution to the world isn't as deep, and, therefore, not as important. This may come across in subtle ways, but it isn't too far-fetched to imagine Analysts announcing it out loud. Thanks to their rationality, Virtuosos may feel the sting a little less, but nobody is immune to feeling hurt when someone treats them as "less than."

Analysts are likely attracted to Virtuosos' more spontaneous, fun-loving nature and see this characteristic as something that could balance their more serious Analyst lives. Too much spontaneity, however, may make Virtuosos appear too frivolous in their Analyst sweethearts' eyes.

Virtuosos may become impatient with Analysts' constant hunger for more knowledge and their need to theorize about everything. Should Analysts go on too long and slip too often into the theoretical, as they do, they may quickly lose their Virtuoso partners' interest. They might even look at their Analyst partners as snooty or out of touch.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Analyst Relationships

Luckily, all isn't lost for Virtuoso-Analyst lovers. Both types can acknowledge their differences and turn them into strengths that neutralize each other's weaknesses.

Let's begin with taking a deeper look at Analysts' seeming lack of emotion. While Analysts may appear at time as though they have no feelings, the truth is they often feel quite deeply. They just don't necessarily feel

comfortable expressing their emotions. Virtuosos may learn in time that it's just as possible to hurt their Analyst partners' feelings as it is anyone else's. Analysts need to come out of their cloud of concepts occasionally, and there's no better way to do so than being invited to play in Virtuosos' playground of discovery. So, rather than becoming irritated at what they perceive as Analysts' stodginess, Virtuosos can encourage Analyst lovers to come along on their adventures (and learn to appreciate their perspectives as well.)

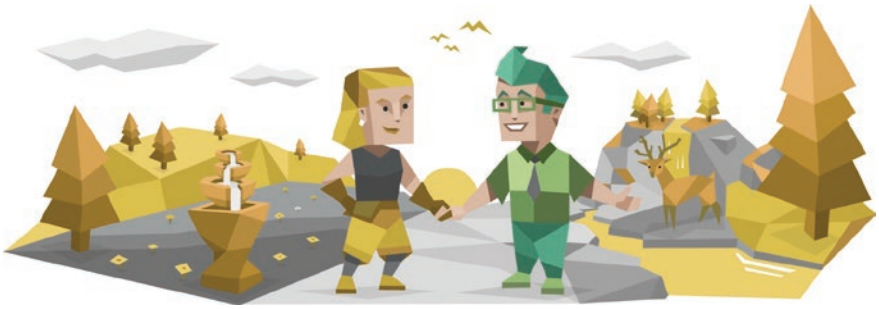
To build better balance into these relationships, try to:

- Bring them into the Virtuosos' world – occasionally. Virtuosos might want to invite their Analyst partners, who typically overthink everything, to try experiences that involve a more hands-on and spontaneous approach to the world. Perhaps introduce them to an artisan craft or to a physical skill like rock climbing or dancing. Physical intimacy is a great way to lure Analysts away from their preoccupations. This call to action should be done in moderation, however. Trying to "fix" Analysts to make them more like themselves may tempt Virtuosos, but there's nothing to fix. They are who they are. But occasional excursions into each other's worlds may help build balance into their shared relationships.
- Save the spontaneity for the right time. Remember that Analyst partners don't share Virtuosos' love for the present moment, and their constant spontaneity may exhaust Analysts. Virtuosos can prioritize and store their spontaneous impulses for use later if necessary. They may want to occasionally make it a priority to skip a beat so that the Analysts they love have the room they need to deliberate without the distraction of the Virtuosos' constant doing. "There's no reason to do this right now. Let's think about it for a bit," may be all Analysts need to hear occasionally from Virtuosos to feel more at home in various situations. Look for opportunities to indulge their preferences.
- Set some ground rules about communication. This is should be easy for two problem-solving types. Accept that neither type is particularly sensitive to feelings, so a communication construct that, for lack of a better word, artificially protects feelings may be helpful. To do this, take an inventory of communication that feels hurtful or demeaning.

From that list, decide what's out of bounds, what isn't, and why. Make rules like using "I feel" statements to take responsibility and avoid directly placing blame, such as, "When you do that... I feel..." This sort of rule not only cues the other partner that they're entering hurtful territory, but deliberately identifying when something touches an emotion can also help each access their feelings more.

Both Analysts and Virtuosos can benefit from taking the time to understand each other's personality types. Suspend judgment and consider that both styles are legitimate – one approach isn't better than the other. Accepting that each type serves a purpose in their relationships can help them to appreciate each other's differences – and, most important, help both Analysts and Virtuosos to resist trying to change each other.

Virtuoso-Diplomat Relationships



Thinking and Feeling types make decisions in markedly different ways. Throw in the Observant and Intuitive trait differences, and Virtuoso-Diplomat relationships are a potential mess – or a glorious example of when two very different people come together and create something wonderful. They have so much to offer each other. Virtuosos add their skilled bias toward practical action, and Diplomats add a deliberate humanistic and visionary counterbalance. When they go beyond tolerating each other's differences to valuing them, great things are likely to happen for these couples.

Balanced Virtuoso-Diplomat Relationships

Diplomats are Intuitive personality types who tend to place heavy emphasis on their Feeling trait, which is why this pairing can be difficult

for Observant, Thinking Virtuosos, who champion practicality over emotion. However, when these differences are accommodated for, Virtuoso-Diplomat love affairs can be dynamic.

Diplomats have heads full of creative ideas and dreams, and they see things through the human values lens. They approach other people with an eye for bringing out their potential and strive to find opportunities for both individual and community growth. They're also romantic and sometimes idealize their relationships, placing the objects of their affection on pedestals.

Virtuosos live fully in the present, and are always looking for what's new and exciting. Rather than focusing on people as their Diplomat partners do, the human factor can come in second for Virtuosos when they have a problem to solve or a skill to master. It's not that they're amoral or that they don't care about people. People usually fascinate them in an objective sort of way – but tinkering with the tasks and problems before them fascinates Virtuosos even more.

When dating, Virtuosos' free spirit and enthusiasm for living in the moment may enthrall Diplomats, who tend to project romantic qualities onto these clever "bohemians." Diplomats are fascinated by Virtuosos' desire for freedom and novelty and their virtuosity expressed through their chosen interests.

Similarly, Virtuosos may, at first, be curious about the almost mystical essence that surrounds Diplomats and their approach to life that feels foreign to this earthbound type. When these two types date, it can be an exciting time full of energy and anticipation. (Virtuosos are playful and enjoy novelty. Diplomats have a fondness for metaphors and symbolism. This combination almost makes these couples perfect candidates for role-playing in the bedroom.)

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Diplomat Relationships

Perhaps the biggest issue with this type combination is that Diplomats may see some Virtuoso behavior as cold-hearted and shallow, while Virtuosos may view Diplomats as dreamy and unrealistic. In time, these

two types may revert to their core preferences – and complain about their differences instead of accepting and even admiring them.

For example, Diplomats may try unsuccessfully to help reluctant Virtuosos go deeper into themselves to discover some greater potential. They may grow tired of their Virtuoso partners' need for new experiences, especially as they can lead to sometimes superficial pursuits. Virtuosos, in the meantime, may become annoyed at what they see as their Diplomat significant others' abstract world of ideas and feelings and try to get them to be more down to earth. Diplomats' tendency to live inside their heads may become a major turn-off for experience-oriented Virtuosos. And, just like that, what they first found exciting and interesting about each other may become a source of frustration or boredom.

These two personality types hold very different values, and this even translates to the bedroom. Virtuosos can feel very little emotional attachment when it comes to sex, seeing it as more a purely physical thing. Meanwhile, romantic Diplomats tend to seek a spiritual experience between the sheets. This can lead to pain and hurt, with Virtuosos not understanding the depths of their partners' feelings, and disappointed Diplomats expecting too much.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Diplomat Relationships

With all romantic relationships, it's recommended that partners take time to learn about each other, and this goes doubly so for Virtuoso-Diplomat relationships. These couples can thrive if they choose to practice acceptance and flexibility. However, they first need to work hard to find common ground and allow themselves to embrace and understand each other's differences.

For Diplomats, it's imperative they understand that, although Virtuosos have the Thinking trait, it doesn't mean they're unemotional. Both Thinking and Feeling personality types are capable of profound emotions – however, Thinking types tend to hide those feelings from the outside world. They want to stay in control and not lose their heads regardless of the circumstances – and this is what creates their aura of indifference.

Likewise, Virtuosos should realize the dominance of the Feeling trait doesn't mean their Diplomat sweethearts are irrational – they're simply using a different set of criteria, putting harmony and sensitivity above cold, hard facts. Feeling types tend to show their emotions quite clearly, as opposed to containing them as Thinking types do. However, their decision process can still be rational.

Both these perspectives are valid, and this is one of the most important lessons for Virtuoso-Diplomat couples to learn. If both partners are tolerant and open-minded, Thinking-Feeling relationships like theirs can be very inspiring and successful, with Virtuosos making fact-based decisions and Diplomats bringing warmth and harmony into their romance.

More than just accepting each other's emotional outlook, here are things that Virtuosos can do to improve their relationships.

- Be tolerant. Remember that Diplomats may not prioritize facts as much they do – they're likely to prioritize harmony, values and morals instead. It's not a wrong way to make decisions, just a different one.
- Attend to emotions and study emotional cues. Diplomat partners are likely to be good at gauging other people's emotional state, and they may expect the same from their Virtuoso lovers. Asking Diplomats about their feelings when they're not clear can help increase Virtuosos' understanding of what is important to them. They can encourage their Diplomat partners to share this perspective – it may lead to better understanding of what might be going on with their significant others and may even help Virtuosos understand feelings in a new way.
- Be careful with criticism. Feeling types like Diplomats are often vulnerable to criticism, and Thinking types like Virtuosos are sometimes excessively blunt – be careful when pointing something out and try to do it in a calm, nonconfrontational manner. It's okay to be honest, but honesty works just as well with a shot of kindness and gentleness most of time. And remember, if a line is crossed occasionally and damage is done, a sincere apology is a good place to start repairing hurt feelings.

- Slow down occasionally. Remember that Diplomats don't share Virtuosos' love for the present moment, and their bias toward action may exhaust these visionaries. Mostly, Diplomats like to stop to consider the consequences before acting and take some time to reflect after. Understanding this difference and honoring it adequately can make Diplomats feel more comfortable in their romances with Virtuosos.
- Learn what is important to Diplomats. Virtuosos' pragmatic and *laissez-faire* attitude toward life may often clash with their Diplomat partners' deeply held values. Adopting a "ends justify the means" approach in morally ambiguous situations may make Diplomats very uncomfortable. Be aware of that and try to find the middle ground between Virtuoso utilitarianism and their idealism. Remember how important their values are to Diplomats. In relationships with them, these things aren't to be trifled with.

Virtuosos' core traits are the opposite of Diplomats' core traits, but this doesn't mean they can't fall in love and share their lives with one another. Tapping into the powerful perspectives of empathy and justice that Diplomats bring can help Virtuosos add those elements to their crafts and solutions. Diplomats who embrace Virtuosos as partners are likely to experience a new practical energy in their lives that can bring them closer to realizing their life's dreams. There is, beyond a doubt, much potential for great romance when these types become couples.

Virtuoso-Sentinel Relationships

While Sentinels and Virtuosos might share many of the same preferences, their contrasting Prospecting and Judging traits make all the difference. Like the rudder on a ship decides its direction, these opposing characteristics tend to turn Sentinels right and Virtuosos left.

However, both these types enjoy a practicality that comes with living in the "here and now." Virtuoso-Sentinel couples don't have to put up with all the theories and abstractions they might with Analysts or Diplomats. Each like to live in a practical, real world where they manipulate material things. In sharing this focus, these sweethearts speak the same down-to-earth language.

Balanced Virtuoso-Sentinel Relationships

Sentinels are Judging individuals and enjoy planning and committing to things, as opposed to keeping their options open. Virtuosos, on the other hand, are always looking for alternatives and opportunities. Relationships between Judging and Prospecting individuals may often be rocky and challenging, but there's a lot of potential for strong, dynamic romance once the two types put in time to learn about each other.

Sentinels and Virtuosos are likely to find common ground in their Observant trait. Both are likely to prefer relying on their senses over introspection – they spend more time keeping their feet on the ground, as opposed to exploring airy spaces filled with ideas. Love affairs between two Observant types are usually very straightforward, practical, and fun – both types of partner can usually handle practical tasks well, focusing exclusively on real, tangible things. Their combination of pragmatism, down-to-earth attitude, and "Let's just do it!" approach is likely to be a great driving force in their relationships, provided Virtuosos don't ask their Sentinel lovers to veer too far afield of the conventional.

Sexually, both Role types have a no-nonsense approach about sex, seeing it as something very physical. Sex stays in the realm of the senses with Virtuoso-Sentinel couples and won't be laden with "deeper meanings" as with Diplomats (and, to some degree, Analysts.)

Steady relationships are likely to evolve more easily for Virtuoso-Sentinel couples than other pairings because they complement each other and provide a perfect *yin* to the other's *yang*. When Virtuosos mature and begin to see the value of settling down, they often gravitate toward Sentinels – who settle rather naturally and enthusiastically.

Even Virtuosos understand that consistency has its place and may look to Sentinels to provide it for them. On the other hand, even Sentinels crave a little excitement in their lives if it's not too disruptive. Sentinels may also find someone they can nurture in their Virtuoso beloveds, satisfying their need to care for others.

It should also be mentioned that, statistically, Sentinels and Virtuosos are quite likely to run into each other in the dating pool. Observant types like Virtuosos and Sentinels form most of the population (75–85%) and many traditions and social norms revolve around their traits as well. Consequently, they're unlikely to have difficulty understanding each other or finding things to do. Like all Observant individuals, both types enjoy things that they can see, touch, and feel – therefore, activities that excite Virtuosos are probably attractive to their Sentinel partners as well, and they won't need to worry about being misunderstood. This is a great advantage both in the early dating phase and later in their long-term relationships.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Sentinel Relationships

The differences most obvious in this pairing involve decision-making and certainty. True to their name, Virtuosos are ever-curious and often reluctant to commit if something feels like it's going to be too restrictive. It's all right with them if everything is a little ambiguous. They like to see where things are going, and they navigate the flow of life instinctively and with great enthusiasm.

Sentinels, on the other hand, like to know that things are going the way they've determined they should (mostly through tradition and habit). They prefer certainty with little room for ambiguity and often declare their truths in absolute terms. On a date, Sentinels may say, "Let's go to our favorite restaurant for dinner and then a movie. Here are the movie listings. Let's pick a movie before we leave." Virtuosos might say, "Let's try that new club downtown. I know nothing about it. I'd love to see what it's like." Should their relationships grow into something serious, these differing attitudes can become very important. Inflexibility and favoring only one's own way is likely to be detrimental to such relationships.

Another issue is that some Sentinel-Virtuoso relationships begin to mimic those of parents and children, with Sentinels acting the part of the grown-ups and Virtuosos taking the role of rascally kids. This can work – until it doesn't. At some point, having all the responsibility of holding the ship steady may cause Sentinels to become resentful, especially if Virtuosos don't express appreciation for their efforts. Virtuosos, in turn, may come to resent being "managed" and treated like infants and may suddenly demand to make their own decisions based on their need for adrenaline and action.

Once Virtuosos become the "rebellious children" in romance, there's a great deal of conflict potential. Sentinels may feel that their stability is threatened, and they, in turn, may double down on the aspects of life that make Virtuosos feel confined. It can all get very messy if these couples don't understand the situation and work with each other to correct it.

Although their combined pragmatism and focus on the concrete are very useful in everyday life, Virtuosos and Sentinels may have difficulties with imagination, reflection, and growth as individuals and as couples. This doesn't mean that Observant types are unimaginative – quite the contrary, they're often brilliant artists. However, their tendency to rely on the sensory world and undervalue abstract, philosophical thoughts often lead their relationships to a stagnant place that lacks meaningful dimension. They may each lack an individual, unique sense of purpose in their romance. Each partner performs in their own style and yet neither is sure why. Should one partner think too much about it, it can disrupt the relationship to which they've grown accustomed.

Mid-life and similar crises are the product of such disruptions. And, like most Explorers, Virtuosos may feel a pull to move on to something new and different regardless of which partner type disrupts the comfortable flow of their relationships.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Sentinel Relationships

Virtuosos and Sentinels, if they're willing to compromise, can turn their differences into major strengths, covering each types' respective

weakness. To achieve this, they need to make conscious efforts to meet each other halfway. Virtuosos should resist the urge to always seek something new and exciting, even when it's very difficult to stick to the plan or manage all the chores. Meeting their Sentinel partners halfway (or more) can make a difference in their relationships.

Here are some things Virtuosos can do:

- Show appreciation. While Sentinels may not ask for it, they're energized by receiving recognition for what they do. Considering the amount they contribute to keep things running smoothly, showing them a little appreciation is a small price to pay.
- Help even when the chores are boring. While precise and diligent with the things that interest them, Virtuosos likely have a much higher tolerance for general disorder when compared to their Sentinel partners. To make Sentinels more comfortable, Virtuosos can keep a close eye on their housecleaning duties, such as making sure to wash their dirty dishes without being asked.
- Be imaginative. Observant couples often focus too much on routines or physical things. Don't be afraid of exploring ideas together without knowing whether they're practical or implementable.
- Keep the flame alive. Remember what the attraction was in first place. This may be essential for Virtuosos who are always looking for something different.

Virtuosos must understand and fully use the complementary nature of their relationships with Sentinels. They should recognize they voluntarily joined with partners who value structure and stability, and need to be aware of the importance of "playing by the rules" within relationships with their Sentinel lovers. They can also show appreciation for all that their Sentinel lovers offer them in the diligent and giving way only Sentinels can.

Virtuoso-Explorer Relationships

Someone to explore with – at least, that's what one might assume is the draw when two Explorers fall in love. But even such a match made in heaven can have nooks and crannies that make them less than perfect under the right circumstances. The Observant and Prospecting combination produces much energy and movement and, when multiplied in Virtuoso-Explorer couples, can be exciting. But doubling these characteristics in romantic relationships can also drain and subject partners to impulsive changes. In Virtuoso-Explorer relationships, both partners need to understand what commitment means to them – and be honest with each other about it.

Balanced Virtuoso-Explorer Relationships

Old saws would have us believe that "opposites attract," as though human hearts were magnets. So, what happens when two people within the same Role group take on romance? What happens when Virtuosos and other Explorers meet and fall in love?

Fortunately for Virtuosos and other Explorers, no two people are alike, even if they share the same basic personality traits. There are adaptations and nuances that prevent relationships between them from being the same as looking into a mirror. Degrees of other traits, such as Introversion and Extraversion, can also come into play. There can be plenty of the differences that keep romance interesting, even among those of the same type. But it's exhilarating for Virtuosos to be with those who are like themselves and share the same need for novelty.

When Virtuosos and other Explorers come together romantically, the emphasis is more likely on the playful and the exciting. Theirs are perhaps the most mercurial of type Roles when it comes to romance. Explorers are more likely than any other type to play the field if they can before they settle down. They may resist being "tied down" in favor of being stimulated by new partners and conquests. They can be flirtatious and enjoy the hunt as much as the conquest. Should Virtuosos find themselves in committed relationships with other Explorers, they're likely to find a level of flexibility not seen among any other paired types.

Also, emotions can run high with this combination, as even Explorers with the Thinking trait are highly influenced by their passions. But while Virtuoso-Explorer couples sometimes engage in heated exchanges, they're short-lived and don't have much impact on how they respond to each other in the long term. Since life is a constant whirl of changes for them, that fight last night is likely "so yesterday" and something to be shrugged off.

Sexually, Virtuoso-Explorer lovers may indulge in experimentation and, should things feel too dull in the bedroom, one or both may seek what they regard as more interesting activities elsewhere. Finding ways to spice up their sex lives while staying home may be crucial to their relationships, depending on their mutual arrangements. However, these types bring all their senses into play during their more intimate moments, and this can make finding novel approaches to sex easier.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Explorer Relationships

The biggest potential problem for Virtuoso-Explorer couples is burnout. These couples often live the philosophy behind the line of the Neil Young song: "It's better to burn out than to fade away." Even the most energetic Virtuoso-Explorer sweethearts can only bear such intensity for so long before it becomes too much. They may tire of too many risks and too much excitement and may need to take measures to create stability and "down-time" within their relationships. Failure of these romances is more likely to come from fatigue and lack of novelty rather than incompatibility. A feeling of constant restlessness can get old, even for the most die-hard Virtuosos and other Explorers.

When in love, both these types are likely to orchestrate large romantic gestures and "wow" their partners. However, once their relationships become routine, they also may quietly slink out the back door, never to be heard from again. At some point (usually with age), most Virtuosos become more domestic and commit to creating homes and families. However, they don't date with such long-term plans in mind. Their decision to settle down may be spontaneous and almost impulsive. Multiply these behaviors by two, and it's easy to see how romance between Virtuosos and other Explorers would be intense and, perhaps, the stuff of soap operas.

Both these types tend not to pay so much attention to either the criticisms or concerns of others, as they're often immune to both. They base marriage on the "here and now," and the rules and standards within their committed relationships may be lax. So, while "I do" means something to them, there may always be a feeling that such a commitment is too final and too iron-clad for their comfort.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Explorer Relationships

However, love affairs between Virtuosos and other Explorers don't have to be just about turmoil and uncertainty. There's plenty of opportunity for shared experiences for two such seekers of novelty. Exploring common interest in the arts, crafts, and even business can keep such couples connected and in tune with one another. Even Introverted Virtuoso-Explorer couples can create stimulating social lives filled with interesting people. The trick for their cohesion is to find as many adventures as possible in which they both can join. Such a bonding of interests can provide creative stimulation and strong romances that last a lifetime.

Here are some tips for Virtuoso-Explorer couples:

- Give partners space. With Virtuosos and other Explorers, familiarity breeds contempt. If too confined, or things become too routine, they may feel a need to escape. It's better to allow a little fresh air into these relationships by providing elbow room than it is to allow perpetual sameness to stagnate into what Explorers might see as a dreary house arrest minus the ankle bracelet. Leave enough room so there's no panicky need to flee.

- Don't forget the future. Virtuosos and other Explorers in committed relationships can get some outside help to tend to their shared future. For example, financial advisers who manage money can be helpful for relationships focused almost exclusively on the present. There's all manner of professionals who can be of service to couples who would rather someone else take care of that kind of stuff, anyway.
- Find an anchor, but one with a long chain. Try to find some downtime together for relaxing and quiet fun. Create some family traditions custom-made to help anchor these relationships. Perhaps, they can sit down regularly to a Sunday dinner together – and take turns adding an interesting new dish to the menu each week. This much consistency typically goes against the natural grain of most Virtuosos and other Explorers, but expanding their comfort zones can build some structure into their relationships. Blending homegrown expressions of togetherness with opportunities for each to independently express themselves can help create a wholesome balance.

To the non-Explorer, a relationship between Virtuosos and other Explorers may sound chaotic and unconventional. But such couples aren't likely to be so concerned with what others think of them. The trick isn't for them to defy their independent, exploratory natures and try to conform to pre-fab expectations. The trick is to learn how to bring those characteristics into their romance in ways that work for them and leave both types happy. Think of it as another solution to find and another avenue to explore.

Conclusion

The words "passion" and "romance" are close cousins, and we often find the word "passion" assigned to descriptions of Virtuoso characteristics. Admittedly, for this type, the word passion is mostly attached to the work and activities that Virtuosos enjoy. But they can also extend that positive energy toward those they love, and, in doing so, form passionate romances. While they choose rationality as their primary tool for making decisions, Virtuosos are far from cold – and they can be very effective soulmates.

Consider how attractive devil-may-care people are, especially to those personality types who need a little relief from the structure and convention that may define their lives. Virtuosos can provide such relief with the fun-loving, unpredictability. But this can be the challenge for such relationships. Sometimes one must be careful of what one asks for. For Virtuosos, the shine often wears off when the reality of their lovers' preferences reassert themselves.

But despite such dangers, love frequently finds a way. There's no such thing as a good or bad match for those Virtuosos willing to put as much effort into nurturing a relationship as they do perfecting a skill. One of the hallmark characteristics of Explorers is their willingness to change course if it leads to practical results, and nothing describes the compromise necessary for a successful relationship with Virtuosos better.

Friendships

Easygoing and Spontaneous Friends

When it comes to friendship, Virtuosos seem made for Bushnell's Law of game design: Easy to learn, difficult to master. With their well-rounded, interesting array of hobbies, people with the Virtuoso personality type have no trouble at all meeting acquaintances with whom to share their activities. Piercing the surface to become their true friend is the real challenge. While they may make a lot of buddies along the way, their combined Introversion and Thinking traits usually leave only a few people with whom they manage a serious connection. They're neither open to having a lot of lifelong friends, nor do they need them to be happy.

Virtuosos simply don't want to be bound to any person or activity. They live in the present, too busy enjoying whatever life brings to feel any real obligation to shift course because of others' plans. If friends don't want to do what they're doing, then Virtuosos are happy to do their own thing. Sometimes their shifts in attitude can catch their friends flat-footed, but Virtuosos' motto remains, "Everything can be changed." Requiring them to commit to scheduled activities is probably the quickest way to end their friendship.

If everyone keeps things relaxed and flexible, though, Virtuosos' companionship can be rich and rewarding. People with this personality type are talented in using their senses, and usually enjoy a little competition. This makes their hobbies – especially more physical activities like fishing and crafts – comfortably enjoyable with a little company, and these activities are usually the basis for many of their

friendships. Virtuosos' interests are diverse, so they should have no trouble coming up with exciting things to do.

Virtuosos are also thoughtful, rational people. Being creative individuals themselves, they often enjoy discussing new ideas – but the point of sharing those ideas must be to act on them. Dreaming is well and good, but talk is cheap, and discussions on abstract or distant subjects like Eurasian politics can only hold Virtuosos' attention for so long before they shift their focus to something in which they can actively participate.

Virtuosos and Friends of Other Types

Virtuosos are unusually popular, almost despite themselves. Their open-mindedness, interesting hobbies, and relaxed attitude are attractive to a remarkably broad range of personality types. With so many acquaintances, Virtuosos are sure to strike up deeper friendships with at least a few people in their lives.

Let's examine the challenges and joys these types are likely to face in friendships with other people belonging to each of the major Roles – Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. We'll look at some ways Virtuosos can balance their style to make their friendships more valuable, fair, and fulfilling.

Virtuoso-Analyst Friendships

Virtuosos and Analysts relate to each other well through their Thinking preference. These friends are likely to have the same bias toward the rational, even though they express it differently. There's a stark honesty that comes with their shared approach which might not be present with friends who are more emotionally inclined. Virtuosos and Analysts

are likely friends who can be blunt and open with each other– if the bluntness isn't applied too thickly. For them, frankness, like all things, is best in moderation.

Balanced Virtuoso-Analyst Friendships

Clever Thinkers Get Along

The best thing about having Analyst friends is that they act as rational, insightful, and strategically minded advisors to highly practical but sometimes impatient Virtuosos. Analysts pride themselves on being objective, even with their closest friends. Those belonging to this type group have few qualms about criticizing Virtuosos' latest ideas or specific actions. Being direct and blunt themselves, Virtuosos are likely to feel right at home when it comes to such an approach. Although Analysts' penchant for conceptual thinking may frustrate them, having others who are able and willing to look at things from different perspectives can often be invaluable.

Virtuosos and Analysts also share a desire for logic and efficiency. Together, they can spend hours tackling challenges, with Analysts trying to understand the principles behind the functionality and Virtuosos working with what's in front.

These partnerships can be mutually rewarding. Their ideals and perspectives may not always overlap, but there's plenty of common ground for both types to benefit from opportunities to share their thoughts with each other.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Analyst Friendships

Deficits in Understanding

Virtuosos and Analysts also have their fair share of differences that may cause tension in relationships between them. The most important of such differences is the way these types take in information. Virtuosos are highly practical, live-in-the-moment individuals – as far as they're concerned, it's the real, tangible things that matter most. Analysts, on the other hand, are absorbed in what they can imagine and deduce.

While there are ways to combine the two approaches (for instance, while working on projects that require both concept and development), these two thinking styles can often turn out to be a major barrier to communication and mutual understanding.

Another issue is that neither type is likely to find it easy to support their friends emotionally. Both Virtuosos and Analysts can have strong feelings, but neither tends to be comfortable or experienced when it comes to coping with other people's emotions. This may not be a major issue in day-to-day matters, but nearly every friendship has ups and downs occasionally – bottling up frustration isn't the best long-term strategy. If they can't resolve these underlying problems, sometimes even a simple miscommunication can lead to long-standing disagreement. In such situations, either Virtuosos or Analysts, being as rational as they are, may ultimately decide that their friendship is just not worth the trouble.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Analyst Friendships

Practical Logic

While these types may have drastically different ways of exploring and thinking about the future, they can rely on their common rationality to resolve any differences within their shared friendships. One very strong trait Analysts and Virtuosos have in common is an appreciation of effectiveness – they both love to see practical solutions in place and functioning. This shared appreciation isn't limited to technical areas, but also applies to the social realm. Particularly in matters of pure preference (where to eat, for example), it's only rational to conclude that the occasional compromise might be in order. Why? Because a friend is worth it.

When these types experience more serious friction with each other, both can dial down their frustrated sense of superiority and instead focus on finding a solution together. Resolving their differing methods and preferences can be as easy as each type opening their minds to see the merits of another perspective and trying it. Likewise, instead of just arguing for their own way, these friends can respect each other's minds enough to justify their arguments with some facts. Telling friends they're

wrong about something only carries hurtful judgement. But showing them better ways that work is a respectful form of disagreement these logical types can handle.

Modeling compromise is one of the best ways to attain this. Doing so not only provides an example of how it's done, but also has compromise built in, thus demonstrating a willingness to meet the other halfway: "I see where you're coming from, and I think you have some great points there."

Virtuoso-Diplomat Friendships

Virtuosos and Diplomats often approach things from different angles: Virtuosos from a rational, practical level and Diplomats from an idealistic, humanistic level. With effort and acceptance, these differences can be complementary and help each type grow. Or, they can set up conflict, as each looks askance at the other's position. But some of the best friendships are between those who have enough in common to connect – and enough differences to keep them interested.

Balanced Virtuoso-Diplomat Friendships

Differences That Inspire

For Virtuosos, having close Diplomat friends can be both a very rewarding and very perplexing experience. They may wonder at each other, but also share much wonder as they come to understand their very different viewpoints and what they can offer each other.

Diplomats are enthusiastic, passionate, and imaginative individuals – their energy inspires Virtuosos, especially initially, and often gives

them exciting new ideas to follow. Diplomats are less common compared to other personality types, and their viewpoints may be very intriguing to Virtuosos. However, this fascination may also include confusion; just like Analysts, Diplomats primarily live in their minds, and this attitude can be foreign to practical-minded, energetically hands-on Virtuosos.

Regardless of these issues, Virtuoso-Diplomat friendships can be inspiring. Empathic and insightful, Diplomats can pull more realistic Virtuosos away from their daily concerns, encouraging them to develop their thoughts and ideas. Diplomats have a knack for making people feel relaxed and comfortable, and restless Virtuosos are likely to benefit from such company. On the other side, idealistic and sometimes overly imaginative Diplomats benefit from friendship with highly practical and efficiency-oriented Virtuosos. They put their ideas into action, and this amazes Diplomats, inspiring them to do the same with their own dreams. As rewarding as ideas can be, often there's just no substitute for some good shared experiences.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Diplomat Friendships

Very Different Priorities

While both types of friends are likely to share a certain excitement about discovering and experiencing new things, they may also remain enigmatic to each other for a very long time. Theirs is probably the most challenging personality type combination of all for many reasons. For one thing, Diplomats' nearly constant soul-searching is as meaningful to them as experiencing things is to Virtuosos. While Virtuosos chase exciting experiences that increase their skillset, Diplomats wonder about what such chasing means to the bigger picture and how it ultimately benefits the growth of those involved. These differences can lead to numerous misunderstandings as their goals and motivations are often at odds.

Another issue that Virtuosos and their Diplomat friends may come across is their shared tendency to neglect day-to-day matters and necessities. Even Diplomats with the typically organized Judging trait aren't always focused on everyday concerns if there's a larger vision

distracting them. Whether it's Virtuosos going on an unplanned road trip a week before their tax return is due, or sending the rent money slipping Diplomats' minds amid their volunteering activities, both types can sometimes find themselves dealing with an unpleasant surprise. Meticulousness (not to be confused with appreciating different broader types of order) isn't either type's strong suit, and both Virtuosos and their Diplomat friends may suffer from a lack of focus on their responsibilities.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Diplomat Friendships

Taking Time to Help Each Other

While these types may not be perfectly compatible when it comes to focusing on their day-to-day lives, they may find they can enhance the richness of each other's lives with a little flexibility. Diplomats maintain a principled sincerity that's remarkable and can beautifully balance Virtuosos' sometimes cynical approach to life. Among Diplomat friends, Virtuosos can connect to social rewards that come from thinking more broadly than just about their own lives. In their search for exciting challenges, Virtuosos may unwittingly pass right by warmer human connections, but with Diplomat friends by their side, even such energetic and logical types can find time to stop and smell the roses.

Regarding rebalancing neglectful attitudes toward everyday life, these types are both far from masters, but can still counterbalance their respective weaknesses. When it's time to focus on those all-too-unexciting necessities, their companionship can provide the missing element of enjoyment. Doing chores and running errands may not be fun, but when Virtuoso-Diplomat pals offer each other their company – and helpful thoughts – they can turn anything into a fun adventure together.

Virtuoso-Sentinel Friendships

Glancing at their personality type letters, Virtuosos and Sentinels may look very similar, but what a difference a single letter can make. Where Virtuosos are spontaneous, Sentinels foster stability. Where Virtuosos are pragmatists who aren't always concerned with the rules, Sentinels uphold every jot and tittle of established standards. These differences, however pronounced, don't necessarily make friendship between the two types impossible. There's much potential when these opposites attract.

Balanced Virtuoso-Sentinel Friendships

Everyday Companions

Sentinels are numerous and are likely to form a significant part of Virtuosos' social circles. These personality types are likely to be loyal, practical, and down-to-earth friends, always eager to offer advice and support. Sentinel friends can help Virtuosos stay focused and realistic when it's necessary – for instance, when they get so caught up in their hobbies or social obligations that they find it difficult to spend time on more mundane yet important matters. Sentinels' patience, stability, and sense of loyalty can be invaluable in situations where Virtuosos feel particularly confused or uncertain about their chosen paths.

Both of these personality types tend to be highly practical, with their feet planted firmly on the ground. As friends, they're likely to focus on activities that engage their senses, such as participating in sports, going on hikes, or working on projects together. More adventurous and spontaneous, Virtuosos may succeed in convincing Sentinels to let go of their serious, composed attitude and simply have fun from time to

time. Similarly, the structured and orderly style embraced by Sentinels can counterbalance the occasional devil-may-care approach of their Virtuoso chums.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Sentinel Friendships

Clashing Senses of Responsibility

The main point of contention in Virtuoso-Sentinel friendships is likely to be their different understanding of freedom and individualism. Virtuosos are famous for their unyielding spirit of independence, seeing many rules and traditions as stifling and redundant limitations. To them, freedom of expression is more important than social cohesion or security.

Sentinels scoff at thinking about someone ignoring social conventions for individualism – from their perspective, stability and security are uppermost concerns, and they're likely to argue that the needs of the many outweigh the needs of the few. These differences may lead to some heated discussions between these friends revolving around flexibility and responsibility.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Sentinel Friendships

Truly Respecting Differences

In Virtuoso-Sentinel friendships, each type brings something different and of value to the table. Accepting and acknowledging this is the key to managing friction or differing perspectives. This doesn't mean they must adopt each other's points of view as their own, but recognizing that different styles can work for different people – and all styles offer something important – can be the insights that sustain these friendships.

Virtuosos can appreciate how Sentinels enjoy the sense of security that low-risk stability brings and respect that what may seem limited or restricted in the short term is the key to their friends' long-term success. Sentinels can appreciate that while a spontaneous, risk-taking approach may not be for them, Virtuosos can – and do – make

it work for their own lives. Sentinels can view their Virtuoso friends with supportive amazement instead of dismay, knowing that, win or lose, they'll likely be able to pick themselves up and begin anew. In true friendships between these types, seeing their chums are happy and successful is more important than being right.

These companions also do well to accept input from each other, as they're both highly skilled in their own ways, and equally capable of giving each other some balance. Sentinels who learn to take measured risks by following in the path of Virtuoso friends can undoubtedly increase their opportunities in life, and Virtuosos who listen to the wise advice of Sentinel friends may sidestep some of their own worst mistakes.

Virtuoso-Explorer Friendships

"Live for the moment" could be the motto for Virtuosos who strike up friendships with other Explorers. The exhilaration of a spontaneous and active relationship is likely to be heady for both types, since they're probably asked to conform and slow down in so many other facets of their lives. However, there's no perfect friendship and even this seemingly seamless match has hazards to avoid – mostly because there can be too much of a good thing.

Balanced Virtuoso-Explorer Friendships

Lively Compatibility

For Virtuosos, having close Explorer friends is like looking into a mirror. All Explorers are practical and inventive individuals, so it's very unlikely that such companions would ever run out of things to do. They prefer to

bond over shared activities, so it's likely that they'll find it easy to maintain their relationships regardless of any difficulties, often pushing each other to explore new hobbies or put more efforts into existing ones.

While such free-thinking types as Explorers may have minor differences, it's likely these two types feel as if they've found kindred spirits when they befriend one another. Explorers' spontaneity, boldness, and willingness to push limits make them fun and interesting, and give them plenty of opportunities to bond with each other. The primary challenge for Virtuosos, however, is probably finding other Explorers (especially with similar hobbies), not keeping such friendships alive.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Explorer Friendships

Shared Chaos

A key challenge for Virtuoso-Explorer friends is likely to come from the same source that fuels their companionship – their similarity. Having friends who think similarly can be fun and reassuring, but it can also put such relationships in a bubble, isolating them from criticism and growth. There's a risk that they may convince each other that their behavior and attitude are fine, even when some obvious issues need to be addressed – such as dealing with mundane yet necessary tasks. Their shared love of spontaneity with little emphasis on responsibility can leave these friends mired in disorder.

Another issue Virtuoso-Explorer friends may face is that they're both likely to place more importance on practical, tangible things than imagination and mental exercises. It can be hard for these friends to encourage each other toward personal growth and thinking through the implications their actions and lives. While Virtuosos and other Explorers enjoy living in the moment, failing to stop and think about the long-term picture occasionally can cause problems.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Explorer Friendships

Embracing New Ideas Together

Virtuosos and other Explorers are very open, and one of the best ways

for these friends to avoid being limited by their similarities is to maintain broad social circles made up of different types of people. Virtuosos are great at figuring out how to fit unusual pieces together and can apply this cleverness to social relationships. Seeking new friends with very different perspectives is an exciting adventure with many possible gains.

One of the greatest things that Virtuoso-Explorer friends can get from connections with diverse people is new perspectives on their own lives. This can help these friends develop beyond just living for the moment and help them to be better strategic thinkers, dreamers, and doers. Virtuosos and Explorers benefit from friendships that encourage them to take a fresh approach to things now and then, balancing out their focus on immediate desires. Such friends may find that not only does this makes their lives more secure, but it also enables them to plan and experience new adventures together. Forethought can open even more amazing opportunities than spontaneity can, because it allows Virtuoso-Explorer friends to inject some of their own preferences into an outcome instead of just making do with whatever happens.

Conclusion

Virtuosos are Introverts, meaning their friends are carefully selected and greatly valued because they're a rare commodity for these quiet types. Their bias toward action is likely to bring an extra measure of energy into the lives of those they befriend, and their rational practicality is likely to broaden or shift their friends' perspectives. Friendship with unique Virtuosos can be something to treasure.

Virtuosos who try to develop friendships are likely to be more anchored and balanced because of those relationships. They aren't always comfortable with their feelings, and bonding platonically with others can help them increase their emotional intelligence. Finding someone who shares their interest, a partner in crime to bounce ideas and schemes off, is a rare prize for these types. Virtuosos may have to give up some of the independence they hold so dear, but the tradeoff may be well worth it.

Parenthood

Open-Minded and Flexible

For parenting, Virtuosos give their children more freedom and opportunity than any other personality type. Nothing is quite as perplexing to Virtuoso parents as their children sitting inside and watching television all day. For these types, it's a big world out there, and it's meant to be explored and experienced. Relaxed, open-minded, and flexible, Virtuoso personalities expect their children to use their freedom wisely and to use it in the name of exploration and experience.

Early in life, this attitude is tremendously beneficial for Virtuosos' children. At this stage, every little thing is a miracle, to be explored with every sense. Blocks don't just have distinct colors and shapes, but smells and tastes, too, and this sensory exploration is right up Virtuosos' alley. As their babies learn motor skills, Virtuoso parents are happy to stack those blocks right along with them. As their children grow and develop more complex abilities, Virtuosos find joy in showing them how to use real tools to build real things.

If Virtuosos' growing children share their basic qualities of spontaneity and passion for physical activities, they're happy to accompany them on just about any activity, be it sports, hiking, or hobby engineering. They don't force any of this on their children, though. Virtuosos see little need to impart their principles and interests on their kids; instead, they choose to just enjoy that their children enjoy doing things.

Struggling with Emotional Bonding

Where Virtuoso parents struggle most, as with their other relationships, is in emotional bonding. They use logic rather than empathy when communicating with their children, preventing them from creating deeper emotional connections. Besides their difficulty with empathy, these parents can also be insensitive. This lack of sensitivity can be especially overwhelming to children with the Feeling trait, who may shut down in the presence of overbearing behavior.

It can be a struggle for Virtuoso parents to address any emotional issues that arise as they're often unaware of their own emotional needs. This can cause a lack of self-awareness and inappropriate emotional expression, which can be both confusing and hurtful when it affects their kids.

For example, Virtuoso parents who are stressed out about situations at work may snap at their school-aged children when they ask for help with their homework. They may not realize their frustration is due to their work situation and not a result of their kids' requests. Angry Virtuoso parents may berate their children for not getting their homework done or even accuse them of not being smart enough to do their homework on their own. Their own emotions can cloud their judgment and create negative behaviors and attitudes that they take out on those around them.

Bridging the Emotional Gap

Insensitivity can create a significant emotional gap between parents and children, but, with the right focus and motivation, Virtuoso parents can build positive, lasting bonds. Thankfully, even though they aren't necessarily empathetic or compassionate, Virtuosos are optimistic and generally good-natured individuals. These traits ensure that they'll put in their best efforts to resolve any issues they may face as parents.

Whether or not they believe that their children's feelings or emotions are valid, at the very least, they can take the time to acknowledge them and show that they do care. Just knowing that their parents acknowledge their emotional needs can make kids feel understood and accepted for who they are. This is especially true for Feeling

children, who often feel as though they're misunderstood or criticized for their more sensitive natures.

Virtuosos can also benefit from having more sensitive parenting partners to help them out in this regard, and the healthy bonds that they form through their shared activities can help to bridge the gap. Virtuosos have the added benefit of direct and understanding relationships – their children aren't as likely to feel as if they must hide their mistakes and challenges, which is the holy grail of parent-child communication.

Parent-Child Type Pairings

Talking about personality types and children is always an interesting proposition. While most see personality as something that's at least partly genetic and inherent, those influences may only lightly touch a child or only be mildly apparent during childhood. Childhood is about experimenting, learning, and adapting. This means their behavior is often exploratory rather than permanently defining. There may be hints of a personality type, but with so much adapting going on, it can be hard to pinpoint their consistent traits exactly. And since children aren't self-aware enough to take a personality test, they don't have the same advantages as adults who can answer questions describing their preferences.

Therefore, when we talk about the Analyst child for example, we are referring mainly to children who may show a preference for a rational approach – even if it's sporadic. But we urge caution toward labeling children until they're older and can communicate their preferences themselves. Childhood is all about discovery, and we advocate giving them a chance to do it on their own and in their own time without the confines of labels. Nonetheless, for the sake of discussion, we'll describe things that Virtuosos may want to notice when parenting children who engage in certain trait behaviors – whether these behaviors are a phase or prove to be more consistent over time.

Virtuoso Parent and an Analyst Child

A Curious and Creative Combination

Analyst-leaning children are likely to be intellectually minded, curious, and very imaginative. Their creativity and open-mindedness are likely to delight their Virtuoso parents who'll be intrigued by their children's willingness to explore the unknown, which is similar to their own pursuits.

Virtuosos and Analysts share an interest in discovering how things work, which is why it's unlikely that Virtuoso parents may have major difficulties communicating with their Analyst children or coming up with interesting activities. Analyst children are focused and determined once they find something that interests them. Virtuosos share this trait, and they'll probably be delighted to see their children are as strong-minded as they are.

Practicality versus Theory

The core engines that drive this exploration and curiosity are different in Virtuosos and Analysts. Virtuosos usually enjoy exploring things simply because they present a challenge, and then either move on to something more interesting, or spend time honing their skills. Like other Explorers, Virtuosos focus on the tangible and the real. Analysts are concerned less about the practical applications of things and more about *why* things work the way they do, from a mostly intellectual perspective. They want to understand the hidden principles, systems, and patterns behind things, even when such knowledge offers few tangible benefits.

Analyst children may not hesitate to question their Virtuoso parents' suggestions or conclusions, often because they're interested in why their parents think the way they do, not necessarily because they don't trust them. However, such questions may also frustrate Virtuosos, who may see such queries as a waste of time and wonder why their children won't simply give something a try or focus on experimenting instead. They may answer their Analyst children's questions with statements such as, "Because it works," or, "This is the best way."

Find Shared Interests

Analyst children are unlikely to require much emotional support, which is probably a relief for rational Virtuosos. Analysts tend to be more self-sufficient than Feeling types – although this may also cause problems when there's a genuine need to open up and discuss something instead of hiding and rationalizing their feelings.

Often, Virtuoso parents bond with their Analyst kids through shared activities and hobbies instead of heartfelt discussions about principles and values. It may be a good idea for these parents to make conscious efforts to encourage their children to participate with them in something they're doing, developing mutual appreciation and understanding in this way.

Virtuoso Parent and a Diplomat Child

An Inquisitive and Open-Minded Pair

Even though Virtuosos and Diplomats are complete opposites on many fronts, there's also some overlap among their traits. To begin with, Diplomat-leaning children are likely to be inquisitive and willing to explore new things. This desire for freedom and creativity is likely

to delight their Virtuoso parents. However, while Virtuosos have an excellent grasp of reality, impressive practical skills, and the ability to focus completely on what's in front of them, Diplomat kids may have difficulties relating to such traits due to their more imaginative interests.

It's likely that Diplomat children can always find something to hold their attention, even without their Virtuoso parents' help. This is likely to delight Virtuosos – however, parents with this personality type should ensure that their children have enough mental stimulation from their activities. Diplomats are idealistic and even somewhat poetic individuals, and these characteristics may baffle their practical and rational-minded Virtuoso parents. While Virtuosos may see planting trees as a fun physical exercise, their Diplomat children may ponder what would happen if everyone in their city did the same – and then cheerfully present that idea to their parents.

Impulsive versus Idealistic

Just like Virtuosos, Diplomat children are also likely to understand the importance of personal responsibility and the ability to make their own decisions. However, Virtuoso parents may confuse this with their own tendency to experiment and push limits. Diplomats seek to develop strong inner principles and pick noble, idealistic goals, and may respond better to activities based on values and principles than rewards and practical benefits. It's worth remembering that Diplomats are much more sensitive and empathic than Virtuosos. Parents belonging to the Virtuoso type must make conscious efforts to connect with their children emotionally.

This is likely to cause most of the tension between Virtuoso parents and their Diplomat kids. Like other Explorers, Virtuosos are very selective about what interests them and have little patience for things that don't fall into that category, whereas Diplomats prefer to dive deep and try to find something fascinating in everything they encounter, even when it promises few tangible rewards. Virtuoso parents may need to at least pretend to be interested in their children's musings or find activities that combine opportunities for personal growth with real-world experiences.

Accepting and Encouraging Differences

Virtuoso parents should remember that their Diplomat children require a different approach compared to what's natural for them, and they shouldn't attempt to "fix" their children's thoughtfulness or occasional naiveté. Rather, Virtuoso parents should try to appreciate (and learn from) their children's enthusiasm, open-mindedness, and imagination.

Diplomats' abilities are often underappreciated and rejected as offering little practical value, so a little encouragement can go a long way. Such issues are even more important during the teenage years. Thankfully, being nonconformists themselves, Virtuoso parents are likely to encourage their Diplomat teens to pursue things that inspire and motivate them and help them along the way, instead of criticizing their habits or pushing them to look for more conventional career paths.

Virtuoso Parent and a Sentinel Child

Practical and Perceptive

Virtuosos share the Observant trait with their Sentinel-leaning children, so communication is likely to be relatively uncomplicated between them. Both types focus on practicality and facts, preferring to leave theoretical and abstract conversations to Intuitive Analysts and Diplomats. Virtuosos' expectations are straightforward, and their Sentinel children always know exactly where they stand with their parents.

The Observant trait also has a bearing on how these types experience their environment, and both Virtuoso parents and Sentinel children are perceptive and focus on what is happening around them in the moment. Virtuosos who take the time to become familiar with their

children's behavior may notice even subtle changes that allow them to respond quickly and efficiently to prevent situations from escalating to unmanageable levels. This perceptiveness is especially important for Virtuosos who tend to be insensitive and lacking in empathy.

Not Enough Structure

Sentinel children are likely to be very dutiful and obedient, trying hard to meet expectations. They'll respect family hierarchy and traditional roles, and tend to need their parents to set up a structured environment with well-defined rules. Sentinels aren't comfortable figuring out what's acceptable through trial and error the way Virtuosos are – they prefer a clear understanding of what's okay and what isn't in advance. This is rarely a concern for freedom-minded Virtuosos, although as parents they're likely to appreciate their children's willingness to cooperate and listen to what they have to say.

Sentinel children need a safe, stable atmosphere above all else. Spontaneity and fun can come after their parents meet these needs. Virtuosos should recognize these different needs and remember that their Sentinel children will be careful, conventional, and methodical in their exploration of the world. Children are far more conforming and structure-seeking than Virtuosos, whose somewhat *laissez-faire* approach to parenting may not address their needs.

Respecting the Need for Stability

Sentinel children, like many young children, need stability to build trusting relationships with their parents. Sentinels find comfort in stability and structure more than any other personality type, and they'll struggle with parents who don't provide this environment for them. Although they thrive on spontaneity and adventure, Virtuoso parents must modify their behavior to best meet their kids' needs, especially in their early stages of development. From keeping a consistent feeding schedule to creating a bedtime routine, Virtuosos can create the sense of security and dependability that their Sentinel children best respond to.

It's also important for Virtuosos to respect their children's aversion to risk-taking. Sentinels aren't generally comfortable with thrill-seeking,

making them less likely to be interested in riding a roller coaster or trying new foods. While they benefit from moving outside of their comfort zone every so often, it's important to do this slowly and with their approval – breaking their Sentinel children's trust by pushing them into uncomfortable situations is one of the most harmful mistakes parents can make.

Start by adding new spices to food they already like instead of forcing them to try a foreign food. Take them for a ride on the carousel and then gradually introduce them to more intense rides. Virtuoso parents may find that Sentinel children who can take their time trying new things may be much more willing to push their limits on future adventures. Remember, living up to expectations is critical in developing their self-esteem, so care should be taken to expect only what is reasonable.

Virtuoso Parent and an Explorer Child

Adventurous and Independent Duo

Naturally, Virtuoso parents are likely to find it easiest to communicate with their children if they belong to one of the Explorer types. Explorer-leaning children are very adventurous and practical, and are often able to come up with exciting activities on their own if they're encouraged and given enough freedom to express themselves. Virtuoso parents are likely to be fascinated by their children's curiosity, finding it easy to relate to and communicate with them. Explorer children feel very in tune with the present moment and the world around them, often enjoying direct experiences with sports and nature. Nature-related activities are likely to form a large part of Virtuoso parents' repertoire.

Like Virtuosos themselves, Explorer children are also likely to place a lot of importance on freedom and independence, often insisting on being allowed to experiment and do things in their own way. Virtuosos cherish seeing their curious and enthusiastic children discover something new or exhaust themselves while spending hours on recently acquired hobbies. Such an improvisational and hands-off attitude is a double-edged sword, however. Knowing that their kids love freedom of action, Virtuosos may be reluctant to discipline them for overstepping their boundaries with all those experiments, or to be firm in telling their children that playtime is over, and they should get back to studying.

Missing the Big Picture

Tangentially, Virtuoso parents may also have difficulties encouraging their Explorer children to find time for introspection and personal development. All Explorers are far more interested in real, tangible matters than internal discussions or abstract ideas, but both approaches have valuable things to offer – it's way too easy to forget to find time to stop and think about the direction their lives are going if they live mostly in the present. Virtuoso parents may want to make conscious efforts to look for ways to teach their children that while exploring is fun, sometimes it pays off to take a break and reflect on the reasons for their actions.

Finally, as Virtuoso parents focus more on improvisation and thinking on their feet, they tend to have difficulties with purely administrative and practical tasks. Their Explorer children may likely share this weakness, which is why parents with this personality type should make conscious efforts to teach their kids the importance of being economical, to make fact-based decisions, and to know how to combine their restless curiosity with attending to practical needs and responsibilities.

Considering the Future

As pleasant as it can be to live in the present moment, Virtuosos may be doing their Explorer children a disservice by neglecting to consider their future. Encouraging their Explorer kids to view life as an adventure seems harmless enough, but children who lack direction or the ability to form well-organized plans can venture into some unsavory situations. Going to college with absolutely no direction can cause frustration and

some hefty student loans with no practical degree to show for it. Buying their first car without budgeting for payments, insurance, or fuel can cause a repossessed vehicle and a badly damaged credit score.

To prevent these potentially long-term issues, Virtuoso parents should be intentional in encouraging their children to consider how their present actions affect their future. Children of all ages (even adolescents) aren't cognitively capable of understanding the full potential consequences of their behaviors, so it's their job as parents to help them until they develop those abilities.

As impulsive individuals themselves, Virtuosos may need to explore how their lack of planning or direction may have affected their lives. Anecdotes about poor decisions they made as children – "I decided to try some beer at a friend's party my sophomore year in high school" – and the negative outcomes resulting from those decisions – "I got really sick, and my parents grounded me for two months when they found out" – can help to illustrate the importance of considering future consequences.

Conclusion

Balancing their refreshing spontaneity and somewhat permissive attitude with the responsibilities that come with parenthood can be challenging for Virtuoso parents. But if they master the right approach, they not only raise children who are capable and responsible, but they also manage to build in an element of whimsy and adventure. It doesn't matter what personality type their child turns out to be. Providing smart discipline and lessons in responsibility with Virtuosos' unique personality style can help their children experience the best of both worlds.

Responsible parents always adapt themselves, regardless of their own core inclinations, to raise their children compassionately and intelligently. If Virtuosos see parenting as a skill to acquire and try to do so, they're likely to be marvelous, conscientious parents who open unique doors in sometimes unconventional ways.

Final Words

It's a common saying that "every relationship is work," but for Virtuosos, this statement takes on a very literal meaning. Virtuosos must work against their instincts to balance their strongly rational nature with the legitimate emotional concerns that are inherent to being involved in a romantic relationship, maintaining long-term friendships, and raising children. They must work to find healthy ways to keep things interesting when life settles into a routine. It takes real effort to walk the line between carefree whimsy and attending to the responsibilities that spring from the bonds and intertwined lives that these kinds of relationships entail.

Luckily, Virtuosos can approach the "work" of building positive connections like they do any of the hands-on projects that they are known to enjoy. They strive to be experts at tinkering with and fixing things, an attitude that serves them well in the nonphysical world of relationship maintenance.

In these pages, we've discussed common tendencies that Virtuosos bring to their romantic relationships, friendships, and their roles as parents. We've also provided different strategies that may help make the work of relationships a lot easier for Virtuosos. Our hope is that these insights will inspire their natural curiosity and the "all-in" attitude that is required to build vibrant and inspiring bonds that last a lifetime.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you better understand and strengthen your relationships? Explore our Relationships Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Virtuoso Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Virtuoso Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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